

BIDCRAFT

VFX SCRIPT BREAKDOWN · BIDDING · SCHEDULING

Turn a raw screenplay into a tagged VFX breakdown, build a department-by-department bid, plan the crew ramp and support crew, compare bidding rounds, and produce vendor-ready packages — all in a single, offline, no-install tool. Your scripts and numbers never leave your machine.

COMPLETE USER MANUAL

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1 What BidCraft Is

BidCraft is a browser-based tool for VFX supervisors and producers that takes a raw screenplay all the way to a vendor-ready bid and a crew schedule.

It runs as a single file in any modern browser — no install, no login, no internet required after first load. Everything you type stays in your browser's local storage on your own machine; nothing is uploaded.

The five pages

Breakdown

Paste or import a script, format it into screenplay layout, then select the text describing each effect and tag it with VFX categories, complexity, assets and notes.

Bidding

Every tagged shot and asset becomes a spreadsheet row; every department a column. Enter days, set rates, apply templates, and watch costs total live — in days or weeks.

Review

Flag the shots and assets that need discussion and capture the director's answers in dedicated Producer and VFX Supervisor note fields.

Compare

Snapshot a bid, then compare any two rounds to see exactly what changed — by scene, by shot, and by asset, with day and cost deltas.

Schedule

Set the show's key dates, build a manual crew ramp from the bid, and plan production & supervision support crew — with a running budget.

Privacy by design. Because BidCraft is fully local, you can use it on confidential unreleased scripts. There is no server, no account, and no telemetry.

2 Getting Started

Opening BidCraft

Double-click the **Project_BidCraft.html** file and it opens in your default browser — Chrome, Edge, Safari or Firefox. That's the entire setup; everything works immediately, including offline.

Installing as an app (optional)

For BidCraft in its own window with a dock or taskbar icon, the PWA package can be installed via Chrome or Edge. Because browsers only allow installation from a web address, serve the folder locally and install from the address bar:

1 Serve the folder

In the unzipped PWA folder run `python3 -m http.server 8080` (or any static host / intranet).

2 Open it

Visit `http://localhost:8080` in Chrome or Edge.

3 Install

Click the install icon in the address bar. BidCraft opens standalone and works fully offline thereafter.

Blocked by IT? If your administrator disables PWA installs, launch a clean standalone window with Chrome's app mode: a desktop shortcut whose target ends in `--app="file:///path/to/index.html"`. No server needed.

The interface

A single compact bar across the top holds everything: the **BIDCRAFT** logo, a **project switcher** (new / rename / delete), the five page tabs — **Breakdown, Review, Bidding, Compare, Schedule** — and on the right a **File** menu, a **sun** (brightness) button, and the **Project settings** and **Studio settings** cogs. The bar is deliberately slim to keep the work area as tall as possible.

Autosave is automatic. BidCraft saves to your browser continuously. To move data between machines or keep a hard backup, use File → Save project (section 10).

3 The Breakdown Page

Where a script becomes a tagged breakdown. The left pane holds the script; the right pane holds the tagging tools.

Getting your script in

- **Paste** — copy text from a PDF, Word, or Final Draft export straight into the script pane. Pasted text is cleaned to plain text so it reflows to the page width.
- **Import script PDF** — from the File menu, a drag-and-drop dialog reads a script PDF locally and rebuilds its line structure.
- **Import shots from Excel / CSV** — from the File menu, load a spreadsheet of shots (see section 10). A preview lets you map columns before they're added.

Format Screenplay

The **Format Screenplay** button in the script pane header rebuilds pasted text into clean screenplay layout: it detects scene headings (INT./EXT.), strips page numbers, bolds ALL-CAPS cues, and centers character names. Run it again any time after pasting.

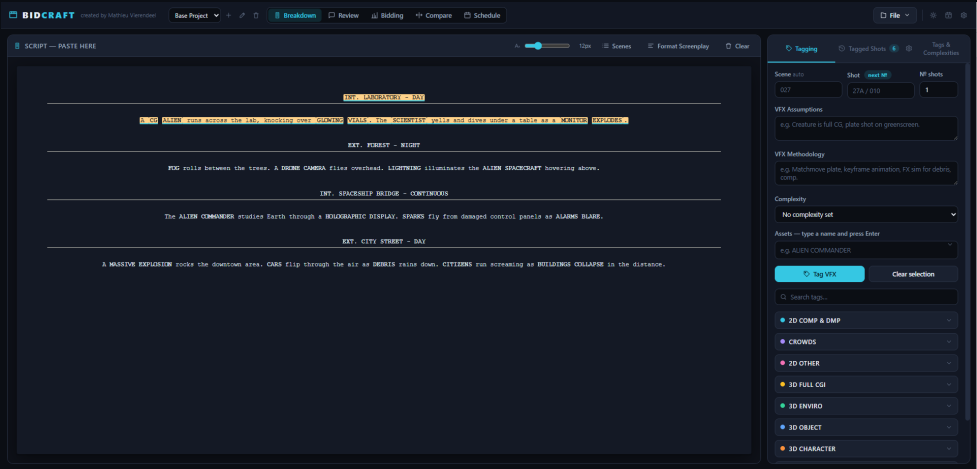
Reading aids

Control	What it does
Font slider	Scales the script text size.
Scenes	Opens a sidebar of every scene heading with its number and shot count. Click to jump.

Selecting & tagging text

- 1 Select the text**
Highlight the words describing an effect — across scene headings, action and dialogue. The whole selection stays highlighted yellow while you set up the tag.
- 2 Set scene, shot & count**
Scene auto-fills from the heading above. Type a shot number (or press 'next No' for the next clean increment). Set 'No shots' if the selection represents several shots.
- 3 Pick tags, complexity, assets & notes**
Choose VFX tags, optionally a complexity level, add assets, and fill the VFX Assumptions / Methodology fields.
- 4 Tag VFX**
Press Tag VFX (or Ctrl/Cmd + Enter). The yellow selection becomes a gold tagged highlight and a card appears in Tagged Shots.

Highlights are linked. Click a gold highlight to jump to its card; click a card to jump back to the script. Deleting a tagged shot removes its highlight automatically.



4 Tags, Complexities & Assets

The building blocks you attach to each shot, all customizable in the Tags & Complexities tab.

VFX tags & groups

Tags are organized into colored **groups** (2D Comp & DMP, Crowds, 3D Full CGI, 3D Enviro, 3D Object, 3D Character, 3D FX, Previs, Assets, and more). In the Tagging tab they appear as collapsible accordions; tick any number per shot, and a search box filters across all tags. In Tags & Complexities you can rename tags, reassign groups, add your own, or delete unused ones.

Complexities & levels

Each complexity has a **name** and a numeric **level**. The level appears in the bidding sheet's Cx column so you can sanity-check difficulty at a glance.

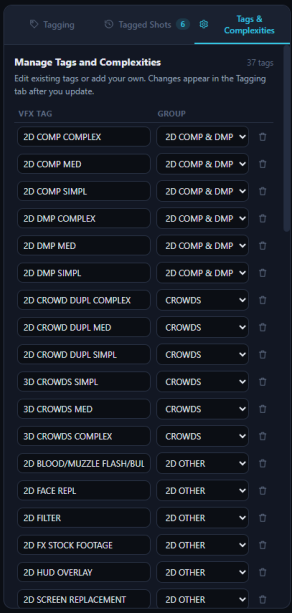
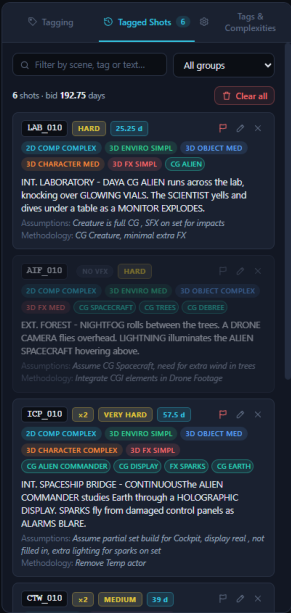
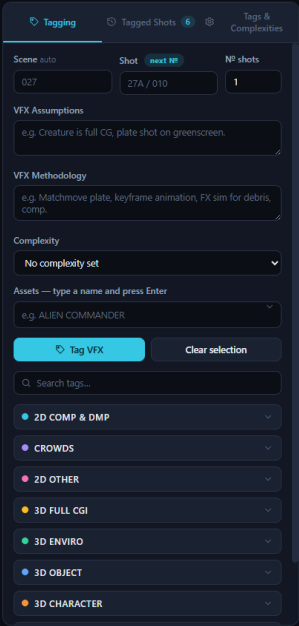
Complexity	Level	Typical use
VERY EASY	1	Simple paint-outs, single-element comps
EASY	2	Screen replacements, basic cleanup
MEDIUM	3	Set extensions, moderate comps
HARD	4	Full CG objects, integrated FX
VERY HARD	5	CG characters, complex simulations
COMPLEX	6	Hero full-CG shots, multi-discipline

Assets

Assets are reusable items — a creature, vehicle, or environment — that appear across many shots. Type an asset name and press Enter to add it; it joins a dropdown you toggle per shot. Start typing an existing name and press Tab to autocomplete.

- **Rename** an asset and it updates on every shot at once — from the Tagging tab or directly in the bid grid.
- **Delete** an asset and it's removed from all shots, with a warning showing how many.
- Assets get their own rows in the Bidding sheet's Assets tab, so you can bid asset builds separately from shot work.

Set up once, reuse everywhere. Your tags, complexities, departments and rates can be saved as a Settings file (section 10) and imported into every new show.



5 The Bidding Page

A full spreadsheet where every tagged shot and asset is a row and every department a column. It behaves like Google Sheets.

Two sheets, sequences & filters

Tabs switch between **Shots** and **Assets**. On the Shots view, rows are grouped by **sequence** (the scene part of the code) under collapsible headers that subtotal days and cost. Three filters — by asset, tag, and group — narrow the rows and combine.

The columns

Column	Meaning
Shot / Asset	The frozen identifier. Editable — type SCENE_SHOT to rename a shot, or a new name to rename an asset everywhere.
Description	The selected script text (wraps).
Cx	Complexity level (shots only).
#	Number of shots/assets the row represents — multiplies days & cost. Set to 0 to park a row (see below).
Departments	One editable day-count cell per department (vertical headers fit many).
Days / Weeks	Sum of department days x the # multiplier, shown in the current time unit.
Producer Offset	A manual +/- adjustment added to the row's cost.
Cost	Days x rates x # + offset (appears once any rate is set).

Count of zero = parked

Set a row's # to **0** to exclude it from everything — its days and cost drop out of the totals, the department day counts, and the schedule. The bid row greys out with a “**no vfx**” tag and the matching Tagged Shots card greys too. Useful for holding a shot in the bid without it counting.

Navigation, templates & manual rows

Click a day cell and type; Enter/down and the arrow keys move between cells. Bid one row, tick it, **Save as template**, then tick others and **Apply to selected**. A template fully overwrites a row's department days — departments the template doesn't include are cleared, not left behind. **Add shot / Add asset** creates a row that wasn't tagged from the script.

Bulk actions

Tick any rows, then open the **Bulk** menu (with a live count of what's selected) to act on them all at once: select all / clear, set complexity, add a tag, set No shots, park (No = 0), flag or unflag for review, clear department days, **duplicate** the rows (clones with a fresh shot number, or a “NAME COPY” asset), or delete them. Each is a single undoable step.

6 The Review Page

A focused workspace for the shots and assets that need discussion — ideal for a spotting session with the director.

Flagging

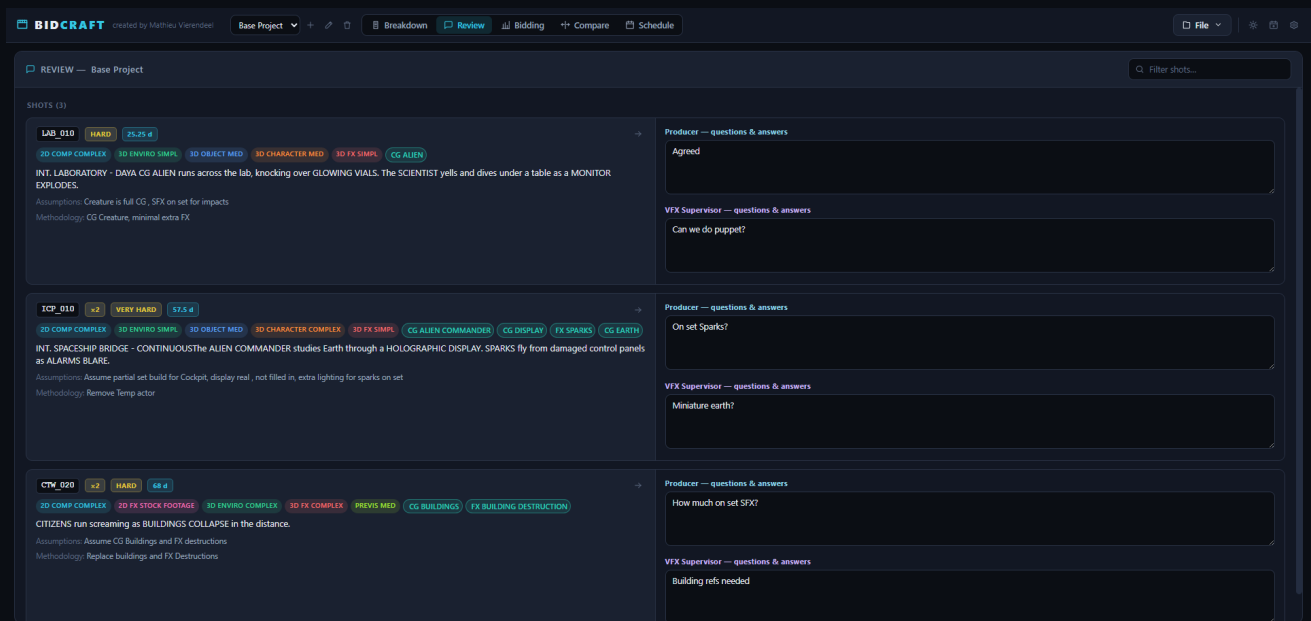
Every shot (on its card and its bidding row) and every asset has a **flag icon**. Click it red and that item is flagged for review. Only flagged items appear on the Review page; everything else stays out of the way.

The Review cards

- **Left** — the shot's full context: code, badges, tags, assets, description, assumptions and methodology, with an arrow to jump to it in the script.
- **Right** — two free-text notepads: Producer — questions & answers, and VFX Supervisor — questions & answers.

Capture what the director says, open questions and decisions as the conversation happens. Notes save live and travel with the project; flagged assets get their own cards with the same two fields. Unflag an item to clear it from the list.

A live spotting tool. Sit on the Review page during a session: click a card's arrow to see the shot in context, then type the answer straight into the Producer or VFX Sup field.



7 The Compare Page

Bids change as the cut changes. Snapshots freeze a dated copy of the numbers so you can see exactly what moved between rounds.

Snapshots

Press **Snapshot this bid** to freeze the current numbers — every shot and asset's days and cost, plus totals — as a named, dated copy saved with the project. The list shows each snapshot's date, shot/asset counts and totals; each can be renamed or deleted.

Comparing two rounds

Two dropdowns let you compare any snapshot against another — or against the live current bid. You get a summary (delta days, delta cost, delta shot count, color-coded red for increases and green for decreases) followed by collapsible sections:

- **Scenes** — aggregated day & cost change per scene, shown first for the big picture.
- **Shots** — every changed shot, grouped under its scene, with new / removed badges.
- **Assets** — every changed asset build.

How producers actually work. Snapshot at the end of each bidding round; when the next cut arrives and numbers shift, the Compare page tells you precisely where the budget moved.

BIDCRAFT

created by Mathieu Vierendeel

Base Project

+

+

+

Breakdown

Review

Bidding

Compare

Schedule

File

+

+

+

COMPARE — Base Project

Snapshot this bid

Compare

Bid 2026-06-14 — 2026-06-14

against

Current (live)

Snapshots are saved with the project.

SNAPSHOTS (2)

Bid 2026-06-13

2026-06-13 · 5 shots, 10 assets

347 d · \$326275

Bid 2026-06-14

2026-06-14 · 6 shots, 10 assets

378 d · \$354825

COMPARISON

Bid 2026-06-14 — Current (live)

Days

Cost

Shots

+8

+\$6775

0

CHANGES

Scenes

4 changed

Item	Bid 2026-06-14	Current (live)	Δ days	Δ cost
LAB	24.25	25.25	+1	+950
AIF	22	0	-22	-30525
CTW	81	107	+26	+23500
DDH	0	3	+3	+2850

Shots

4 changed

Item	Bid 2026-06-14	Current (live)	Δ days	Δ cost
SCENE AIF - 1 SHOT				
AIF_010	22	0	-22	-30525
SCENE CTW - 1 SHOT				
CTW_010	13	39	+26	+23500
SCENE DDH - 1 SHOT				
DDH_010	0	3	+3	+2850
SCENE LAB - 1 SHOT				
LAB_010	24.25	25.25	+1	+950

9 Studio & Project Settings

Two cogs at the top-right of every view: a calendar for Project settings, a gear for Studio settings.

Project settings (calendar)

Holds the show's **key dates**: Start and Final delivery at the top, then a list of turnovers labelled **TO01–TO10**, and below that a **Custom milestones** section where you add your own named dates (start edit, trailer delivery, lock — up to 20). Each milestone appears on the schedule as a gold card and a gold marker line. The schedule rebuilds whenever you change a date.

Studio settings (gear)

- **Department day rate** — set one rate and apply it to every department column at once.
- **Currency** — USD, EUR, GBP, CAD, AUD, JPY, CNY. Labels the cost totals; it does not convert the numbers.
- **Time unit** — Days or Weeks, with a days-per-week value. Bids are always entered and stored in days; Weeks just divides the displayed figures.
- **Support & overhead rates** — day-rate presets for VFX Supervisor, Producer, Coordinator, General Overhead (add your own). These are the roles offered when adding support crew on the Schedule page.
- **Features** — toggle whole modules on and off (section 11).

Currency labels, it doesn't convert. Changing currency relabels the cost totals; it does not apply exchange rates to the numbers you've entered.

10 The File Menu & Exports

Everything for getting data in and out lives in one File menu at the top-right, grouped by purpose.

Import

- **Import script PDF** — read a screenplay PDF locally into the script pane.
- **Import shots from Excel / CSV** — load a spreadsheet of shots (.xlsx or .csv). A preview dialog auto-maps the columns to BidCraft's fields (with dropdowns to re-point or skip any), detects per-department day columns and offers to create new departments, then adds the rows to the current project. The format mirrors the Breakdown export, so export → edit in Excel → re-import round-trips cleanly. Rows are added, not merged, so re-importing the same file twice makes duplicates.

Export

- **Export to Excel** — a real .xlsx workbook with four sheets: Breakdown (every shot with tags, complexity, assets, days, offsets, descriptions, notes and Q&A), Summary (totals and distributions), Bid (the shot x department and asset matrices), and Schedule (the artist ramp and support crew, with budget and cost).
- **Export to CSV** — a flat breakdown file. Scene and shot numbers keep their leading zeros (001 stays 001).
- **Export for ShotGrid** — two CSVs shaped for ShotGrid's importer: a Shots file (code, sequence, description, status, tags, complexity, assets, # shots, bid days, Q&A) and an Assets file.

Project & settings

- **Save / Load project** — a complete backup of one show (script, highlights, shots, assets, bids, snapshots, schedule, notes). Use it to move a show between machines or hand it to a colleague.
- **Export / Import settings** — only the reusable setup (tags, groups, complexities, departments + rates, currency, templates, overhead presets), with no project content. Build your studio standard once and import it into every new show.

Why save explicitly? Autosave lives in your browser, which can be cleared by “clear browsing data,” private windows, or cleanup. Save project after meaningful work for a portable, durable copy.

11 Appearance & Feature Flags

Light / dark

The **sun button** (top-right, left of the cogs) flips the entire app — script page, frame, panels and all — between dark and light, wherever you are. Tagged highlights stay readable in both.

Hiding features

Studio settings → Features lets you tailor the app to a job:

- **Budgeting** — turning it off removes the Bidding and Compare tabs entirely, so the app becomes a pure breakdown + review tool.
- **Scheduling** — turning it off removes the Schedule tab.
- **Hide all prices** — keeps bidding and scheduling fully usable but blanks every monetary figure across the app — useful when sharing a screen where costs shouldn't be visible.

Reduce to essentials. With Budgeting and Scheduling both off, BidCraft is just Breakdown and Review — a clean spotting and tagging tool with no numbers in sight.

12 Full Tutorial — Bid & Schedule

End to end, from a fresh script to a costed bid and a crew plan.

1 Create a project

Click + in the project switcher and name it after your show.

2 Bring in the script

Paste the screenplay, or File > Import script PDF. Press Format Screenplay to clean the layout.

3 Load your studio settings

File > Import settings to drop in your standard tags, departments, rates and overhead presets (or use the defaults).

4 Tag the effects

Select each effect's text; set scene, shot and number of shots; tick tags; set complexity; add assets; write an assumption. Press Tag VFX. Repeat through the script.

5 Bid it

On the Bidding page set rates (Studio settings > department rate) and currency. Enter days for one representative shot, Save as template, then tick similar shots and Apply to selected (a template fully overwrites their days). Use the Bulk menu to set complexity, duplicate or park many rows at once. Bid the assets on the Assets tab.

6 Park anything on hold

Set a shot's # to 0 to keep it in the breakdown without it counting toward days or cost.

7 Flag & review

Flag uncertain shots; on the Review page note the questions for the director.

8 Snapshot the round

On Compare, press Snapshot this bid so you can measure changes after the next cut.

9 Set the dates

In Project settings enter Start, Delivery, the turnovers, and any custom milestones (start edit, trailer delivery, etc.).

10 Build the schedule

On the Schedule page, type heads per week per department (watch the budget column), then Add support role for production & supervision and schedule them too.

11 Export

File > Export to Excel for the full package (now including the schedule), Export for ShotGrid for the pipeline, and Save project as your backup.

13 Shortcuts & Tips

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl/Cmd + Enter	Tag the current selection (Breakdown)
Ctrl/Cmd + Z	Undo the last destructive action (outside text fields)
Enter / down	Move down a cell in the bid grid
Arrow keys	Move between bid cells
Tab / arrows	Confirm a ramp cell and move to the next week (Schedule)
Tab	Autocomplete an asset name while typing
Esc	Close a popup or the File menu

Tips for speed

- Build a **settings file** with your standard tags, departments, rates and overhead presets and import it into every show.
- Use **bid templates** for repetitive shot types instead of typing days row by row.
- Use **No shots** to represent a run of identical shots as one entry; set it to **0** to park a shot.
- Lean on the **sequence groups** and filters to bid one sequence, department or asset at a time.
- **Snapshot** each bidding round so Compare can show you what changed.
- **Save project** regularly — autosave is convenient, but a saved file is your real backup.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
A change doesn't appear	Hard-refresh; the offline cache can be sticky after updates.
Leading zeros lost in Excel	The CSV writes scene/shot as text — open the file fresh rather than re-importing a stripped copy.
PDF import asks for internet	The PDF engine loads once online, then is cached. Offline, paste the text instead.
Lost data after clearing browser	Restore from your most recent saved project file.